

In grounded theory, the integration of theoretical literature is based on the data analysis. It typically leads to a multidisciplinary approach and the incorporation of different scientific fields. In this research the theoretical integration includes, for example, economic and social sciences as well as behavioral research.

Results

Based on the data analysis and literature integration, the study concludes that the preservation of built heritage is often subject to randomness. This randomness also explains the contradiction between the preservation goals for built heritage and its practical implementation. The factors leading to randomness and contradiction are divided into three parts according to the research questions.

1. The growth economy and consumer culture

The prevailing growth economy and consumer culture, which are influenced by the neoliberal phenomena of the market economy, competition, and privatization, are societal and cultural factors that create contradiction. In this way of thinking, the starting point for decision-making is not an environmental perspective or what kind of development is desirable, but economic growth policy and profitability requirements. A similar phenomenon occurs in other societal issues, for example in forest discussions. When environmental policy has been shaped according to the goals of economic growth, regulation does not encourage the sustainable development of the built environment. However, reducing the consumption and waste of materials conflicts with the goal of the growth economy and is therefore politically difficult. Businesses have significant power in the growth economy from the perspective of regulation as well.

Most of the decisions concerning built heritage are made in municipalities as part of the land use and construction processes. Yet municipalities have conflicting goals: they strive for growth and competition while also aiming to protect the cultural and natural environment. Municipalities are also increasingly dependent on private investments.

Not all municipalities have the expertise to assess environmental issues. The municipalities' lack of knowledge and will regarding built heritage issues has long been recognized. When enacting the Land Use and Building Act, it was considered that increasing municipal self-government (planning monopoly) requires the maintenance of supervision by state administration authorities and actual opportunities for citizens to participate in and influence their own environment. Today, these requirements have been forgotten. They have not been taken care of, and, in many cases, they have even been weakened.

This study raises the question of what is the justification for the current state of municipal planning monopolies when the municipalities lack expertise and resources, consultants do most of the work, and planning is a sector known to be prone to structural corruption.